that work has had a positive impact on them, that it has made them feel more independent, experienced, and capable."[23]

The health revolution, and its emphasis on maternal and child health, dramatically improved the lives of women. In the 1950s, only half of the births in Cuba took place in a hospital. With an infant mortality rate of 60 out of 1,000 and a maternal mortality rate of 120 out of 100,000, childbearing was a risky business. By the 1990s, over 99 percent of births were taking place in a hospital, and the infant mortality rate had been reduced to 10 per 1,000 – at a par with the far richer United States. Contraception and abortion became widely available.

As educational and work opportunities – and demands – increased for women, so did conflicts between their traditional domestic roles and their work lives. Women had long held the primary responsibility childcare, cooking, and maintaining the home. In the film *A Portrait of Teresa*, the protagonist's mother sighs when her daughter complains about her competing responsibilities. "Women will always be women, and men will always be men," the mother informs her daughter. "Even Fidel can't change that."

One revolutionary solution was to socialize some of women's traditional activities. Day care was dramatically expanded, and came to incorporate educational and health roles as well, at a low cost. Neighborhood centers were open from 7 am to 7 pm, and provided meals and medical check-ups. But the demand for day care greatly outpaced the government's ability to supply it. In the 1980s and 1990s, Cuba had over a million women workers – and only 100,000 day-care slots.[24]

Providing food for their families was also traditionally a woman's role. The rationing system and ongoing scarcities meant that obtaining food was often a laborious task, requiring hours of waiting in multiple lines. Cuban families, explain Benjamin and her colleagues, "buy their rationed goods in four places: the *bodega*, or grocery store, for the monthly 'food basket'; the *carnicería*, or butcher shop, for meat and chicken; the *puesto*, or vegetable stand, for fruits and vegetables in season; and the *lechería*, or dairy store, for bottled milk. Not only do they shop in four stores, but they often stand in line at each one. This